



free will
and
determinism

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "against compatibilist free will" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

**against
compatibilist
free will**

against
incompatibilist
free will

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the reality of free will.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

A compatibility believer in free will rejects premise (1). An incompatibilist believer in free will rejects premise (2).

Let's start with (2), which says that Compatibilism is false.

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2) or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one for (2), and one for (3).

Compatibilist views of free will can be hard for some to get their minds around. How **could** I have free will if everything about me is, ultimately, determined by factors outside of my control?

It may help to sketch one story of compatibilist theory of free will to help you to see why the view should be taken seriously. What does it take for an action of yours to be free?

Consider the action of choosing a salad at the dining hall. Suppose that
you know that the following are all true:

But it seems that all of these things are compatible with determinism
being true.

First, people could pick salads in a world in which determinism is true. Yes, their picking the salad would be fixed by the prior state of the world plus the laws of nature; but they would still be picking salads.

You picked
the salad.

You wanted
to pick the
salad.

If you had
wanted to pick
something else,
you would have.

Second, people could want things in a world in which determinism is true.

Yes, their having that desire would be fixed by the prior state of the world

plus the laws of nature; but they would still want things.

Third, it could be true in a world where determinism is true that, if someone had different desires than they really have, they would have acted differently. Yes, in order to imagine a world in which their desires are different, we have to imagine a world in which the past or the laws were different in some way. But it could well be that if the past and laws were changed in a way that would make their desires different, their action would have also been different.

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

reality of free will.



The master argument against the reality of free will

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

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or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

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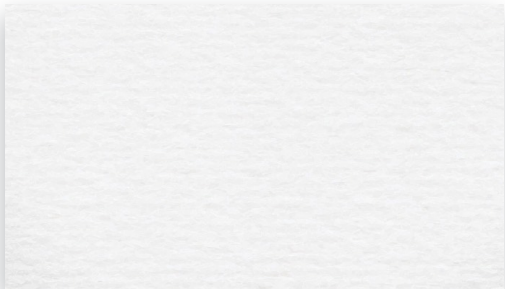
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1. No one has any choice about events which

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

about whether @.

varlatatie + the last of the

then DECISION. (4,5)

then DECISION happens. (3)



3. If determined, the only one

and none has any choice about whether,

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

theorie about the fact that if DNR

future is not distant with the state of the



happened in the distant past.

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

of interest.

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

combination of four - that No

choice about the laws of nature, then no

This argument seems to show that the

one has any choice about the past, no

rules out free will.

choice principle, and determinism

seems to show that if determinism is

Since the first three of these theses

seem quite plausible, the argument

hence that free will is incompatible with

true, there are no free actions — and

dearminism.



Real/|the master argument:

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

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